

[Multivitamin/mineral Supplements: Fact Sheet for Consumers \(original version\)](#)

Multivitamin/mineral Supplements: Fact Sheet for Consumers

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What are multivitamin/mineral (MVM) dietary supplements?

Multivitamin/mineral (MVM) supplements contain a combination of vitamins and minerals and sometimes other ingredients. People refer to them by many names, including multis and multiples or simply vitamins. Each of the vitamins and minerals in MVMs has a unique role in the body. For more information about each one, see our individual vitamin and mineral [fact sheets](#).

MVMs cannot take the place of eating a variety of foods that are important to a healthy diet. Foods provide more than vitamins and minerals. They also have fiber and other ingredients that may benefit health.

What kinds of multivitamin/mineral supplements are available?

Many types of MVMs are available in stores and online. Companies choose which vitamins and minerals—and how much—to include in their products. There isn't a standard MVM or a standard list of ingredients.

Among the most common MVMs are basic, once-daily products that contain all or most vitamins and minerals in amounts close to what is recommended.

Some MVMs contain higher than recommended amounts of some vitamins and minerals. These products may come in packs of two or more pills to take each day.

Manufacturers promote some MVMs for specific purposes, such as better athletic performance or energy, weight control, improved immunity, or eye health. These products often contain herbal and other ingredients (such as green tea, coenzyme Q10, probiotics, or glucosamine) in addition to vitamins and minerals.

The recommended amounts of nutrients vary by age and sex and are known as Recommended Dietary Allowances (RDAs) and Adequate Intakes (AIs). However, supplement labels use the Daily Value (DV) for each nutrient, which is often, but not always, similar to the RDA or AI for that nutrient. The %DV for each nutrient will show you how much (what percentage) a serving of the product contributes to reaching the DV.

What are some effects of multivitamins/minerals on health?

Here are some examples of what research has shown about taking MVMs to increase nutrient intakes, improve health, and reduce the risk of disease.

Increase nutrient intakes

Taking an MVM increases the amounts of nutrients you get each day. This can help you get recommended amounts of vitamins and minerals when you cannot or do not get enough of them from food alone. However, taking an MVM can also raise the chances of getting too much of some nutrients, such as iron, vitamin A, zinc, niacin, and folic acid, especially if you take a product that contains more than the recommended amounts of some nutrients. For information about recommended amounts, see our individual vitamin and mineral [fact sheets](#).

Some people take an MVM as a form of dietary or nutritional insurance. Yet people who take MVMs often consume more vitamins and minerals from food and beverages than those who don't.

Health promotion and chronic disease prevention

It is difficult to determine whether MVMs provide health benefits because studies often use different products, making it hard to compare their results. Also, many MVMs are available, and manufacturers can change their composition at will, so it's hard for researchers to study whether specific combinations of vitamins and minerals affect health. Also, people with healthier diets and lifestyles are more likely to take MVMs, making it hard to identify any benefits from the products alone.

Scientists have studied whether taking MVMs affects the risk of health problems and diseases such as cancer, heart disease, osteoporosis, lung disorders, and psychiatric disorders and the risk of death. Most studies have found that taking MVMs has little or no effect on these health outcomes.

Cancer

Overall, it's unclear whether taking an MVM affects cancer risk.

One large study found that male physicians age 50 and older who took a basic MVM for about 11 years had a slightly reduced risk of developing cancer—but not of dying of the disease—compared with those who took a placebo. In another large study in men and women age 60–65 years and older, those who took a basic MVM for about 3.6 years did not have a lower risk of developing cancer, except for lung cancer. Other studies found conflicting evidence. For example, various studies have found that MVMs might increase, decrease, or not affect the risk of breast cancer in women. Some studies suggest MVMs might reduce the risk of colon cancer but increase the risk of prostate cancer, lung cancer, and leukemia in men.

Cardiovascular disease

Overall, MVMs appear to have little or no effect on the risk of cardiovascular disease (CVD).

Most studies in men and women comparing MVMs to a placebo have found that the MVMs do not reduce the risk of CVD, including heart attacks or strokes or resulting deaths. Most other studies of people who take MVMs on their own have found that these products do not protect against CVD either.

Cataracts and age-related macular degeneration

A specific combination of vitamins and minerals can slow down vision loss from age-related macular degeneration (AMD), an eye disease that can blur your central vision.

The Age-Related Eye Disease Study (AREDS) showed that people with AMD and/or cataracts who took a daily supplement of high-dose vitamin C (500 mg), vitamin E (400 IU), beta-carotene (15 mg), zinc (80 mg), and copper (2 mg) for about 6 years had a lower chance of developing advanced AMD. They also had less vision loss than those who did not take the supplement. However, the supplements did not reduce the risk of

getting AMD or the risk of cataracts. A later study showed that the supplement was equally effective without beta-carotene.

Pregnancy and birth outcomes

Prenatal MVM supplements can help pregnant women get enough nutrients, especially key nutrients such as folic acid and iron. Pregnant women who are at risk of malnutrition might be less likely to have a baby that is premature or has a low birth weight or small size if they take an MVM during pregnancy. However, for pregnant women who already get enough of all nutrients, MVMs might not make any difference.

Other outcomes

Several studies have examined the link between MVM use and conditions such as osteoporosis, lung diseases, psychiatric disorders, and even risk of death. Most found that MVMs have no effect on these health outcomes. However, a few studies found that older people who took an MVM for 1 to 3 years had improved cognitive function, memory, and related mental skills.

Should I take a multivitamin/mineral?

People who don't get enough vitamins and minerals from food alone, are on low-calorie diets, have a poor appetite, or avoid certain foods (such as strict vegetarians and vegans) might consider taking an MVM. Health care providers might also recommend MVMs to patients with certain medical problems.

Some people might benefit from taking MVMs or certain nutrients they contain. For example:

- If you might become pregnant, getting 400 mcg/day of folic acid from fortified foods and/or dietary supplements lowers your baby's risk of birth defects of the brain and spine.
- If you are pregnant, a daily prenatal MVM can help ensure you get enough folic acid, iron, iodine, and vitamin D during pregnancy. Your doctor might also recommend separate supplements of iodine and choline, which are often missing or in too small amounts in prenatal MVMs.
- If you are pregnant and eat a vegetarian or vegan diet, your doctor might suggest other nutrients including vitamin B12 and the omega-3 fatty acids DHA and EPA.
- Breastfed babies might also need a vitamin B12 supplement if their nursing mother is low in B12 or eats a vegan diet.
- Breastfed and partially breastfed infants should receive vitamin D supplements of 10 mcg (400 IU)/day, as should non-breastfed infants and toddlers who drink less than 1 quart per day of vitamin D-fortified formula or milk.
- If you are older than 50, you should get recommended amounts of vitamin B12 from fortified foods and/or dietary supplements because your body might not absorb enough of the B12 that is naturally found in food.
- If you are 60 or older, taking an MVM might help maintain or improve cognitive function, memory, and related mental skills.

Can MVMs be harmful?

Taking a basic MVM is unlikely to harm your health. However, if you consume fortified foods and drinks (such as cereals or beverages with added vitamins and minerals) or take other dietary supplements, make sure that the MVM you take doesn't cause your intake of any vitamin or mineral to go above the upper limits. (For more information on upper limits, see our individual vitamin and mineral [fact sheets](#).)

Smokers, and perhaps former smokers, should avoid MVMs with large amounts of beta-carotene and vitamin A because these ingredients might increase the risk of lung cancer.

If you get too much vitamin A during pregnancy, your baby may have an increased risk of birth defects. This risk does not apply to beta-carotene (the form of vitamin A in plant foods, such as carrots, and some dietary supplements).

Do MVMs interact with medications or other dietary supplements?

Basic MVMs don't usually interact with medications, with one important exception. If you take medicine to reduce blood clotting, such as warfarin (Coumadin and Jantoven), talk to your health care provider before taking any MVM or dietary supplement with vitamin K. Vitamin K lowers the drug's effectiveness and doctors base the dose partly on the amount of vitamin K you usually consume from foods and supplements.

Which kind of MVM should I choose?

Talk to your health care provider about whether you should take an MVM and, if so, which one is best for you. Basic MVMs provide many vitamins and minerals close to the recommended amounts. However, the amounts of calcium and magnesium in these MVMs are usually low.

Also, you might consider choosing an MVM designed for your age, sex, and other factors (such as pregnancy). These MVMs may contain a combination of vitamins and minerals better suited to your needs. For example, prenatal MVMs often provide vitamin A as beta-carotene. Most children's MVMs provide nutrients in smaller amounts that are right for them. MVMs for older adults (sometimes called senior or 50+ products) usually provide more calcium and vitamins D and B12 and less iron than MVMs for younger adults.

MVMs and healthful eating

People should get most of their nutrients from food and beverages, according to the federal government's *Dietary Guidelines for Americans*. Foods contain vitamins, minerals, dietary fiber, and other components that benefit health. In some cases, fortified foods and dietary supplements are useful when it is not possible to meet needs for one or more nutrients (for example, during specific life stages such as pregnancy). For more information about building a healthy dietary pattern, see the [Dietary Guidelines for Americans](#).

Where can I find out more about MVMs?

- For general information on MVMs
 - Office of Dietary Supplements (ODS) Health Professional Fact Sheet on [Multivitamin/mineral Supplements](#)
 - ODS [Dietary Supplement Label Database \(DSLDB\)](#)
- For information on recommended intakes of vitamins and minerals
 - ODS [Vitamin and Mineral Supplement Fact Sheets](#)
 - [Nutrient recommendations: Dietary Reference Intakes \(DRI\)](#)
 - Online [DRI tool](#)
 - [Daily Value \(DV\) tables](#)
- For more advice on choosing dietary supplements
 - ODS [Frequently Asked Questions: Which brand\(s\) of dietary supplements should I purchase?](#)
- For information about building a healthy dietary pattern
 - [Dietary Guidelines for Americans](#)

Glossary

absorption

In nutrition, the process of moving protein, carbohydrates, fats, and other nutrients from the digestive system into the bloodstream. Most absorption occurs in the small intestine.

Adequate Intake

AI. The recommended daily intake of a nutrient estimated by the Institute of Medicine to meet or exceed the amount needed to maintain adequate nutrition for most people in a particular life stage and gender group. An AI is established when not enough information is available from scientific research to

determine a Recommended Dietary Allowance (a dietary intake level that is sufficient to meet the nutrient requirements of most people).

age-related macular degeneration

AMD. An eye disease that results in a loss of central, "straight-ahead" vision. AMD is the leading cause of vision loss in older Americans.

beta-carotene

A carotenoid found in carrots, cantaloupe, apricots, sweet potatoes, pumpkin, winter squash, mangos, collard greens, spinach, kale, broccoli, and other orange, red, and dark green fruits and vegetables.

breast cancer

Uncontrolled growth of abnormal cells in the breast.

calcium

A mineral found throughout the body. Calcium is needed for healthy bones and teeth, for nerves and enzymes to function properly, and for blood clotting. Calcium is found in some foods, including milk, yogurt, and cheese, and in Chinese cabbage, kale, broccoli and fortified foods, such as many drinks, tofu, and cereals.

cancer

A group of diseases in which cells divide abnormally and without control, and spread to nearby tissues and other parts of the body. Without treatment, cancer can stop organs from working normally, damage body systems, and cause the patient to die. Cancer may be caused by multiple factors, such as radiation, sunlight, tobacco, certain viruses, and poisonous chemicals; however, the cause of many cancers is unknown.

cognitive function

Mental awareness and judgment.

colon cancer

Uncontrolled growth of abnormal cells in the large intestine (the tube-like organ connected to the small intestine at one end and the anus at the other).

consume

To eat or drink.

control

In a clinical trial, the group of participants that does not receive the new treatment being studied. This group is compared with the group receiving the new treatment, to see whether the new treatment works. In an observational study, the controls are participants who do not have a particular health condition; the control group is compared with the group of participants who do have the condition to see if certain factors (such as diet, activity level, or use of dietary supplements) may be associated with developing or preventing the condition.

copper

In nutrition, a mineral the body needs (along with iron) to make red blood cells. Copper also helps keep the immune system, blood vessels, nerves, and bones healthy. Copper is found in some foods, including oysters and other shellfish, whole grains, beans, nuts, potatoes, organ meats, dark leafy greens, and dried fruits.

Daily Value

DV. A term used on a food or dietary supplement label that tells you how much of a particular nutrient (such as calcium) one serving of the food or supplement provides. DVs are given as percentages and help you compare one product with another. For example, a food that lists 40% DV for calcium would provide much more calcium than another food that lists 10% DV for calcium. For each nutrient, there is one DV for all people aged 4 years and older. DVs are established by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration.

dietary fiber

A substance in plants that you cannot digest. It adds bulk to your diet to make you feel full, helps prevent constipation, and may help lower the risk of heart disease and diabetes. Good sources of dietary fiber include whole grains (such as brown rice, oats, quinoa, bulgur, and popcorn), legumes (such as black beans, garbanzo beans, split peas, and lentils), nuts, seeds, fruit, and vegetables.

Dietary Guidelines for Americans

Advice from the federal government to promote health and reduce the chance (risk) of long-lasting (chronic) diseases through nutrition and physical activity. The Guidelines are updated and published every 5 years by the US Department of Health and Human Services and the US Department of Agriculture.

dietary supplement

A product that is intended to supplement the diet. A dietary supplement contains one or more dietary ingredients (including vitamins, minerals, herbs or other botanicals, amino acids, and other substances) or their components; is intended to be taken by mouth as a pill, capsule, tablet, or liquid; and is identified on the front label of the product as being a dietary supplement.

disorder

In medicine, a disturbance of normal functioning of the mind or body. Disorders may be caused by genetic factors, disease, or trauma.

dose

The amount of medicine or other substance taken at one time or over a specific period of time.

drug

Any substance (other than food) that is used to prevent, diagnose, treat, or relieve symptoms of a disease or abnormal condition. Also, a substance that alters mood or body function or that can be habit-forming or addictive, especially a narcotic.

effectiveness

In medicine, the ability of an intervention (for example, a drug, surgery, or a dietary supplement) to produce the desired beneficial effect under the usual conditions of care by a health care provider.

evidence

Information used to support the use of a particular screening procedure, treatment, or preventive measure. In medicine, evidence needed to determine effectiveness is provided by laboratory research, clinical trials, and other studies.

folic acid

The form of folate (a B vitamin occurring naturally in food) that is manufactured and used in supplements and fortified foods.

fortified

When nutrients (such as vitamins and minerals) are added to a food product. For example, when calcium is added to orange juice, the orange juice is said to be "fortified with calcium". Similarly, many breakfast cereals are "fortified" with several vitamins and minerals.

glucosamine

Glucosamine sulfate is found naturally in the fluid that surrounds your joints. It is also made from the shells of shrimp, lobsters, and crabs, and can be made in the laboratory. Some people use glucosamine to help prevent arthritis pain.

heart attack

The blockage of an artery supplying blood and oxygen to the heart, resulting in the damage or death of a section of heart muscle.

herbal

Having to do with or made from medicinal or edible plants.

immunity

The condition of being protected against or resistant to an infectious disease.

infant

A child younger than 12 months old.

ingredient

In a dietary supplement, an ingredient is a component of the product, such as the main nutrient (vitamin, mineral, herb, amino acid, or enzyme) or any binder, color, filler flavor, or sweetener. In herbal supplements, the common name and Latin name (the genus and species) of the plant is given in the ingredient list. On a dietary supplement label, the ingredients are listed by weight, with the ingredient used in the largest amount first on the list and the ingredient used in the least amount at the end of the list.

interaction

A change in the way a dietary supplement acts in the body when taken with certain other supplements, medicines, or foods, or when taken with certain medical conditions. Interactions may cause the dietary supplement to be more or less effective, or cause effects on the body that are not expected.

iodine

A mineral the body needs to make thyroid hormones, which control metabolism (the process of turning the food you eat into energy your body can use) and many other essential functions, including bone and brain development during pregnancy and infancy. Iodine is found in seaweed, seafood, dairy products, grain products, eggs, and iodized salt.

iron

In nutrition, a mineral the body needs to make red blood cells, proteins, and enzymes; and for the control of cell growth and cell specialization. Iron is found in some foods, including red meats, fish, poultry, lentils, and beans.

IU

International Unit. A measurement used to measure the activity of some vitamins and other biological substances (such as enzymes and hormones).

label

When referring to dietary supplements, information that appears on the product container, including a descriptive name of the product stating that it is a "supplement"; the name and place of business of the manufacturer, packer, or distributor; a complete list of ingredients; and each dietary ingredient contained in the product. Supplements must also include directions for use, nutrition labeling in the form of a Supplement Facts panel that identifies each dietary ingredient contained in the product and the serving size, amount, and active ingredients.

low birth weight

A baby weighing less than 5.5 pounds at birth. Low birth weight babies are at risk of sudden infant death syndrome (SIDS), infections, delayed development (for example, sitting, crawling, and talking), learning disabilities, and other health conditions, such as breathing problems, cerebral palsy, and heart disorders.

lung

An organ in the chest that supplies oxygen to the body and removes carbon dioxide. There are two lungs in the body.

magnesium

In nutrition, a mineral the body needs for normal muscles, nerves, and bones. It also helps keep a steady heart rhythm, a healthy immune system, normal blood sugar levels and blood pressure, and is involved in making energy and protein for the body. Magnesium is found in some foods, including green vegetables, beans and peas, nuts and seeds, and whole grains.

malnutrition

A disorder caused by a diet that does not provide enough nutrition, an unbalanced diet, a digestive system that does not work properly, or a problem with absorbing or using nutrients.

milligram

mg. A measure of weight. It is a metric unit of mass equal to 0.001 gram (it weighs 28,000 times less than an ounce).

mineral

In nutrition, an inorganic substance found in the earth that is required to maintain health.

multivitamin

A product that is meant to supplement the diet. Multivitamins contain a variety of vitamins. The number and amounts of these nutrients can vary substantially by product.

niacin

A nutrient that is needed by the body to make energy from food, and for important cellular functions. Niacin is found in some foods, including poultry, beef, pork, fish, nuts, legumes, whole grains, and enriched or fortified breads and cereals. In medicine it is used as a drug to lower high blood cholesterol levels. It is one of the B vitamins. Also called nicotinamide and nicotinic acid.

nursing

Breastfeeding.

nutrient

A chemical compound in food that is used by the body to function and maintain health. Examples of nutrients include proteins, fats, carbohydrates, vitamins, and minerals.

nutritional

Having to do with nutrition (eating, digesting, and absorbing the nutrients in food, and the health and disease consequences).

Office of Dietary Supplements

ODS, Office of Disease Prevention, Office of Director, National Institutes of Health, Department of Health and Human Services. ODS strengthens knowledge and understanding of dietary supplements by evaluating scientific information, stimulating and supporting research, disseminating research results, and educating the public to foster an enhanced quality of life and health for the US population.

omega-3 fatty acid

A main component of fats used by the body for energy and tissue growth. Omega-3s are essential fatty acids in the human diet; they are found in fish oil and certain plant and nut oils.

osteoporosis

A condition in which bones become weak and brittle, increasing the chance they may break.

outcome

A specific endpoint measured in a clinical trial. Examples include weight loss, cholesterol levels, severe toxicity, worsening of disease, and death.

placebo

An inactive substance or treatment that has no effect on the body and that ideally looks, smells, and tastes the same as, and is given the same way as, the active drug or treatment being tested. The effects of the active substance or treatment are compared to the effects of the placebo.

prenatal

Before birth; during pregnancy.

prostate cancer

Uncontrolled growth of abnormal cells in the prostate (a gland in the male reproductive system found below the bladder and in front of the rectum). Prostate cancer usually occurs in older men.

Recommended Dietary Allowance

RDA. The average amount of a nutrient a healthy person should get each day. RDAs vary by age, gender and whether a woman is pregnant or breastfeeding. For example, the RDA for vitamin C is 80 mg a day for a pregnant teenager and 90 mg a day for men. RDAs are developed by the Food and Nutrition Board at the Institute of Medicine of the National Academies.

risk

The chance or probability that a harmful event will occur. In health, for example, the chance that someone will develop a disease or condition.

stroke

A loss of blood flow to part of the brain. Strokes are caused by blood clots or broken blood vessels in the brain, and result in damage to a section of brain tissue. Symptoms include dizziness, numbness, weakness on one side of the body, and problems with talking or understanding language. The chance (risk) of stroke is increased by high blood pressure, older age, smoking, diabetes, high cholesterol, heart disease, a family history of stroke, and a build-up of fatty material inside the coronary arteries (atherosclerosis). See also NIH publication: Know Stroke. Know the Signs. Act in Time.

<http://www.ninds.nih.gov/disorders/stroke/knowstroke.htm>

supplement

A nutrient that may be added to the diet to increase the intake of that nutrient. Sometimes used to mean dietary supplement.

tea

A drink made by adding boiling water to fresh or dried herbs and steeping (soaking) them. It may be drunk either hot or cold. Also called an infusion.

toddler

A child between the ages of 12 months and 3 years.

upper limit

UL. The largest daily intake of a nutrient considered safe for most people. Taking more than the UL is not recommended and may be harmful. The UL for each nutrient is set by the Food and Nutrition Board at the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine. For example, the UL for vitamin A is 3,000 micrograms/day. Women who consume more than this amount every day shortly before or during pregnancy have an increased chance (risk) of having a baby with a birth defect. Also called the tolerable upper intake level.

vegan

A person who eats only plant-based foods. Vegans do not eat meat, poultry, fish, eggs, milk, dairy products, or honey, and do not use leather, silk, or wool, or soaps and cosmetics that are made from animal products.

vegetarianism

The practice of avoiding all or most animal products for environmental, philosophical, and health reasons. Vegetarians (people who practice vegetarianism) eat a diet based on foods that come from plants and may include some dairy products and eggs. See: vegetarian diet.

vitamin

A nutrient that the body needs in small amounts to function and maintain health. Examples are vitamins A, C, and E.

vitamin A

A general term for a group of compounds that includes provitamin A carotenoids (found in foods that come from plants) and retinol (preformed vitamin A found in foods that come from animals). The body can use retinol to make retinal and retinoic acid (other forms of vitamin A). Vitamin A plays an important role in vision, bone growth, reproduction, immunity, cell development, and skin health. Vitamin A is found in some foods, including eggs, liver, fortified milk, cheese, leafy green vegetables (such as spinach, kale, turnip greens, collards, and romaine lettuce), broccoli, dark orange fruits and vegetables (such as apricots, carrots, pumpkin, sweet potatoes, papaya, mango, and cantaloupe), and red bell pepper.

vitamin B₁₂

A group of chemical compounds that contain cobalt and are needed for certain chemical reactions in the body. Vitamin B₁₂ is involved in maintaining healthy nerve cells and red blood cells. It is needed to make DNA (the genetic material in all cells), and is required for the metabolism (chemical changes that take place in the tissues to produce energy and the basic materials needed by the body) of carbohydrate, fat, and protein. Also called cobalamin. For more information see the NIH Office of Dietary Supplements Vitamin B₁₂ fact sheet.

vitamin C

A nutrient needed by the body to make collagen (a protein found in cartilage, tendons, ligaments, bone, and blood vessels), to absorb iron from food, and for wound healing. It is an antioxidant and protects cells from free radical damage. Vitamin C is found in some foods including citrus fruits, strawberries, peppers, dark green vegetables, tomatoes, and potatoes. Also called ascorbic acid.

vitamin D

A nutrient that is obtained from the diet and can be made in the skin after exposure to sunlight. Vitamin D acts as a hormone. It helps to form and maintain strong bones, maintain normal blood levels of calcium and phosphorus, and increase calcium absorption; it also helps to maintain a healthy immune system and control cell growth. Vitamin D is found in some foods, including some types of fatty fish, and milk and breakfast cereals that are fortified with vitamin D.

vitamin E

A nutrient needed by the body to help keep the immune system healthy and to repair damage to DNA. It is an antioxidant that protects cells from free radical damage. Vitamin E is found in some foods, including vegetable oils, nuts and seeds, fortified breakfast cereals, and spinach, broccoli, kiwi, and mangos.

vitamin K

A nutrient needed by the body to function and stay healthy. It helps form blood clots and maintain strong bones. Vitamin K is found in some foods, including green leafy vegetables, broccoli, liver, and vegetable oils. It is also made by bacteria that live in the large intestine.

zinc

A mineral found in most cells of the body. It helps enzymes work properly, helps maintain a healthy immune system, helps maintain the senses of taste and smell, and is needed for wound healing, making DNA, and normal growth and development during pregnancy, childhood, and adolescence. Zinc is found in some foods, including oysters, red meat, poultry, beans, nuts, certain seafood, whole grains, fortified breakfast cereals, and dairy products.

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